Right now, you are a leader

Leading from the Middle

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Dedication

To those who have helped me along the way,
Thank you for getting me this far.
To those I have hurt and disappointed,
Thank you for teaching me the harder lessons I needed to learn.
To those I haven't met yet,
I look forward to seeing what we achieve together.

Right now, you are a leader. Hard to believe, isn't it? But what if I told you it's true? That every day, you are - without any authority - bringing people together to achieve a common goal.

The journey to this point has been a long one. Longer than I first realised, honestly. I generally say it started not long after moving to London in 2011. But the longer I'm on this journey, the more I think it started well before then. I just didn't see it.

I'm sure you can relate to feeling misunderstood at some point in your life. I was constantly hitting the same wall. No matter how hard I tried, I couldn't master it. I felt that way all through school. I worked hard and had a lot of help from my mum, but I still only achieved average results. I didn't fit in anywhere with the school hierarchy of playground politics either. I remember my final year of high school. I didn't care about graduation. I couldn't wait till it was all over so I could get out of there and far, far away from it all.

Even at university, I found it hard to fit in and feel worthy of being at the same level as those around me. I ended up changing my degree three times during university. Well, I guess it was four, but that's another story for another time.

I changed so often because I was trying to figure out who I was and what I wanted to do in life. For most of us, our passions and dreams aren't always fully clear until later in life, and even then, we may never know what we truly want to do. I found that changing my mind meant I was quietly judged by some (not all) around me, and over time, I stopped sharing my plans. We are expected to know our career path as children, so it's understandable that it can shock people when our minds change.

When I moved to London in 2011, I felt even more like a fish out of water. Culture shock, being so far from my family, and still unsure what was going on in my brain. I could tell the judgments and the feeling of being misunderstood hadn't gone away.

No matter where I was, my brain and I had reached a crossroads. The same patterns followed me. It became increasingly clear that the situations that caused me conflict or stress stemmed from being misunderstood by those around me. Or, worse, I ruined relationships or didn't handle situations well because I didn't recognise that my actions were part of the problem. I knew I had to do something. So began a new journey.

Thankfully, I had a manager who seemed to understand that I was a curious person and always open to learning. He encouraged me to take courses that helped me understand myself, so I could explain to those around me how I worked. Little did I realise that this was just the start.

I don't know the exact moment my thinking shifted from focusing on myself to what it is today. It was a slow dial-turn as I began questioning what leadership in the workplace really means. At one point, I even googled 'What does the word leadership mean?' and 'How do you define a leader?'. Everything I found told me that you had to be a CEO, CTO or someone in a senior role to be a leader. Yet I felt I was already leading.

For example, in my first project manager role, I pulled together several development teams and improved our release process. I didn't line manage anyone on my team, but I was expected to influence ways of working, set an example, and support their growth. I had no authority, yet I influenced and drove change. I adapted to the people around me, supported and guided them through changes, and led colleagues in making department-wide changes to how we worked.

How does that not make me a leader?!

My frustrations peaked when I started going to conferences. Although all the talks I listened to were great in their respective topics, they all did the same thing. Behind the code written, the processes set, and the product direction was the biggest variable of all.

People.

We all have our own human experiences that make us who we are. It's what makes us unique. Yet no one seemed to acknowledge it openly. We only ever danced around it when talking about the external skills that show how we can achieve something.

After years of struggling to fit in, feeling misunderstood, breaking relationships with wonderful people because I didn't understand my limits, and feeling frustrated because I couldn't get anywhere without working a set way, I decided to write about it. I truly believed that if I struggled with this, others out there felt the same way. Who had a story like mine at some point in their life?

When lockdown hit in March 2020, I knew it was time to do it. (Seriously, what else was there to do?) After writing one article, I didn't think about it anymore. I seriously thought that was it. I had no idea my mind would keep pondering it and let it evolve into something far more profound.

Today, Leading from the Middle is about six building blocks. Each one connects to the others, influencing and directing the delicate balance of working relationships.

The building blocks of Leading from the Middle

Building block 1: Analysing your and others' unconscious bias

We are all unconsciously biased. Period. We don't know what we don't know. Yet, every day, our biases play a huge role in how we see the world. When we see how unconscious bias shapes our own and others' working relationships, we can acknowledge it and find ways to address it.

Building block 2: Language has the power to make or break

Human language is one of the human race's greatest achievements. As it has evolved over time, it has become more complex, with different dialects and nuances. By breaking down the barriers in how we communicate, we can build relationships faster.

Building block 3: Learning is an ever-evolving journey

From the moment we are born, we are learning. However, how we all learn is unique to us. We all have our strengths and weaknesses. We need to recognise different learning styles and celebrate being part of a diverse group of thinkers.

Building block 4: There is strength in being mindful

Mental health is too often the elephant in the room: an invisibility cloak we all wrap around ourselves so that people don't see what we are struggling with. We will never know everyone's personal story or how experiences shaped them. However, we can learn to watch for signs when we or others have reached our limits and be more mindful.

Building block 5: Self-awareness of yourself and others

Our behaviour impacts others just as those around us impact us. That is why we need to reflect on ourselves, understand who we are and our limits, and know the value we bring to any conversation.

Building block 6: Build bridges

Through exploring the previous building blocks, we have now built our human element toolkit. We can recognise when we have successfully built bridges in any situation and identify and celebrate our value and worth.

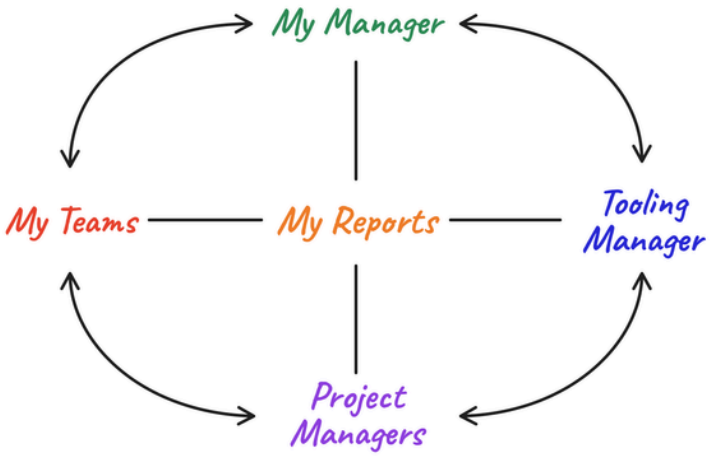
Thinking about all these building blocks when interacting with others is hard. Just as I can name examples of how I've done this successfully, I've also lost count of how many times I have failed. Thinking about each individual and all the intricacies that come with it, all the time, while managing your own emotions can be too much. But we keep trying, and the more we support and understand those around us, who catch us when we fall, the easier it becomes to forgive ourselves and keep improving.

So how does this work? How can you see that you are successfully bringing people together to reach a common goal?

Here is an example. As a project manager, I struggled to build sprint reports for the team. It wasn't that I didn't understand their value; I just struggled to pull out the information and put it into a spreadsheet. Honestly, spreadsheets and I don't get along. As far as I'm concerned, there is a special place in hell for them, where people dance around a fire as they burn. I have tried to learn how to use them over the years, and I have come to accept that we will never understand each other.

But I still have to do it as it's part of my job. So I decided to find a tool that would do it for me. I needed one that could connect to the tools my teams used and automatically create reports, removing my frustration and helping me win the war I was having with the spreadsheets.

I knew I had to get the people around me on board not only to allow this new tool into our tooling estate, but also to ensure others could take advantage of it.



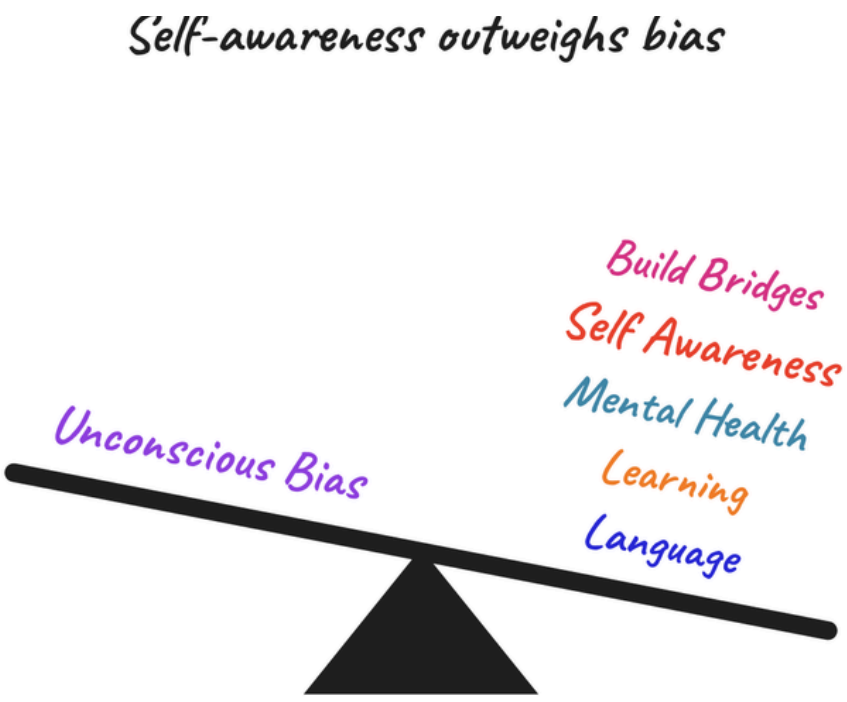
By working with the tooling manager, other project managers, my boss, and my own teams, I brought in this new tool and trained others to use it. This brought new, more detailed team reports and consistency across all department teams, and it also supported portfolio-level reporting.

I influenced and drove change (without any authority) by approaching each level of the business differently, offering different training options, and managing expectations accordingly. Just as I had to influence those around me, they influenced me. We are all unique and bring different ideas and challenges to the table. Recognising and adapting to each individual while leading others is what makes us all leaders.

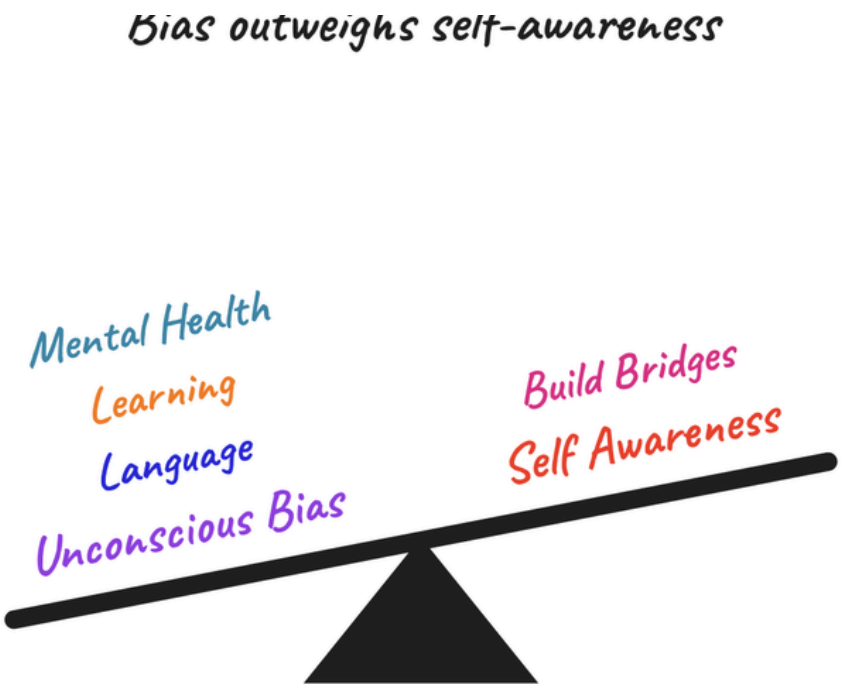
The great circle of life

In The Lion King, Mufasa explains to Simba that the great circle of life is a delicate balance. Each creature, great and small, has a role to play, which is why we are all connected in the great circle of life.

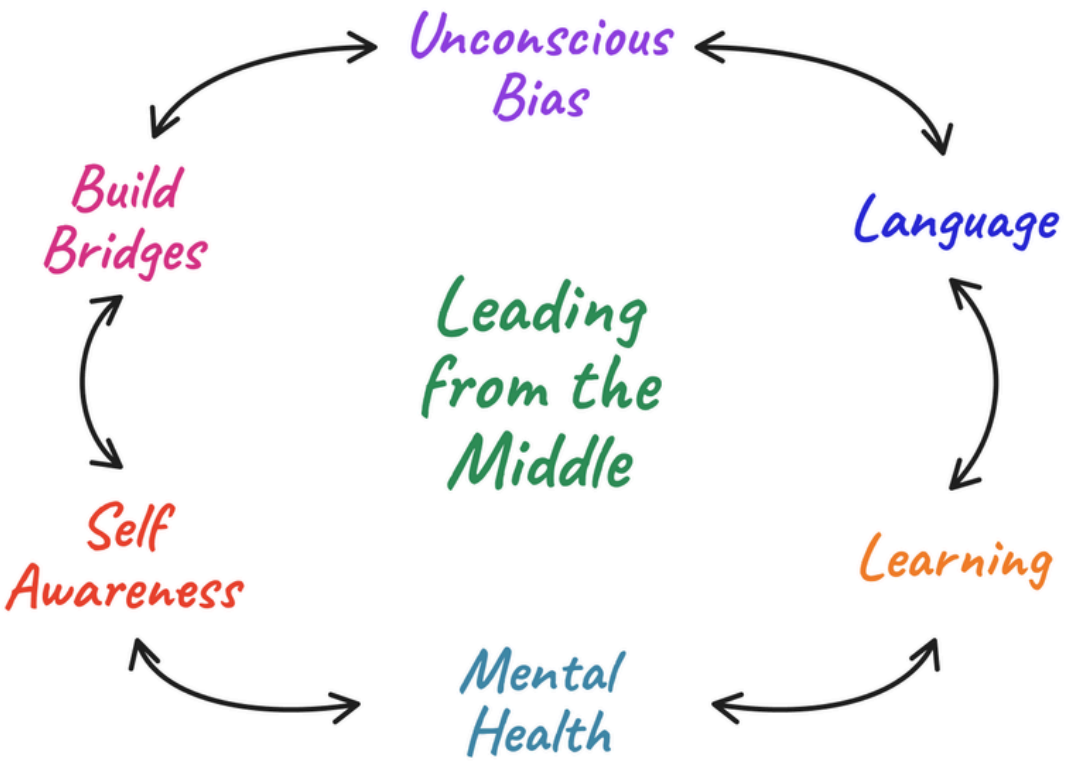
Leading from the middle follows the same principle. We are all connected in our own circles of life. Managing a delicate balance between ourselves and others.



A seesaw easily illustrates the delicate balance of managing each building block and why each building block is set in a specific order. For example, the more our unconscious bias affects how we speak to or treat people, the less aware we are of how our behaviour impacts those around us. Our bias also shapes the other building blocks. The less self-aware we are, the harder it is to build bridges.



The more self-aware we are, the better we can manage, assess, and even predict when areas such as our unconscious bias or language may need to change or affect our conversations. The bridges we build to meet in the middle are easier and more successful overall.



Each building block is different, but we can recognise how each influences the others, even when it is hard to see. If we can recognise how they connect within ourselves, and in others, we can be more open and adaptable to those around us.

What started as a desire to challenge people's perceptions and ways of thinking has grown into a desire to support those who have struggled, just as I have. I also want to share ideas and tools to help them showcase the value they bring to their role.

That is why I now help individuals unlock the leader within themselves. Everyone has a story. I want to hear those stories and help them on their journey to unlock and celebrate who they are.

Just remember. Whatever happens, you bring value to your role. No one else can do what you do, and that is why I celebrate you.

Get in touch!

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